

Will the World Achieve Great Unity?

Zhihu

No matter by what path, no matter how tortuous the road, the great unity of the world is inevitable.

On the level of material production, the globe is already a single economy: production is already distributed across the world at the level of industries. Transnational vertical division of labour within industries, global production networks, global value chains — these are already the most commonplace economic facts. Politically, however, they are not: the global market is carved up into some two hundred states. Economic unity against political fragmentation is one of the principal contradictions of our age.

The war in Iran has proved that a single country, for its own needs, can hold the global economy hostage. With the spread of drones, missiles, and similar technologies, all powers above the middle rank are gradually acquiring this capacity to dominate a region; whenever it serves their needs, they can brandish the disruption of the global economy as a bargaining chip. When I discussed the Iran war I predicted that Iran's actions would gravely disturb the global economy. The global bourgeoisie is inevitably intensifying its lobbying of the great powers, China among them, to press urgently for a ceasefire (see my answer: "Iran's foreign minister says Iran is willing to allow Japanese vessels to pass through the Strait of Hormuz — how should we view this statement? What considerations lie behind it?").

While the global economy is still in its growth phase, with vast unindustrialised regions able to satisfy the demands of capital accumulation, the frequency of war can remain relatively low. When even the last frontier of capital expansion — regions such as West Africa — has completed its industrialisation and urbanisation, global positive growth will fall into stagnation (see my article: "The Long-Run Trend of the Rate of Profit in the Capitalist Mode of Production"). Economic stagnation inevitably drives unemployment upward and sharpens internal contradictions. That sharpening may open the way for the beginnings of transnational unity among the proletarians. From the rulers' standpoint, of course, they wish to block this process, and their only means is to launch wars — to manufacture national estrangement through war and divert attention.

But such wars can only end in disrupting supply chains, causing shortages and rising prices, and quickly earning the revulsion of people the world over. Once or twice, people may still look into which side has the better case; after eight or ten times, what remains among the masses is nothing but a deep disgust with war itself. During China's Beiyang period, warlord warfare began in 1916; within a few short years the common people could bear it no longer, and the Nationalist Party rose with the

slogan "Down with the imperialists, out with the warlords" — a measure of how detested the warlord wars had become. At that time China's urbanisation rate was extremely low and most of its people were peasants, yet even they reacted so. In a highly urbanised, industrialised global economy, such chronic "warlord" warfare will inevitably give people everywhere the desire to eliminate the warlords and to seek unity.

Global unity may well become the goal of a popular movement from below. But in order to control that movement, the ruling classes will certainly propose reformist schemes from above — most likely by strengthening the UN and the related economic organisations, establishing a global central bank, forming global armed forces, and by such steps gradually building a world government. What kind of world government is to be built, and on what principles unity is to be achieved — these will be the focal point of struggle between the proletariat and the bourgeoisie.

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